

*Agkistrodon contortrix*

Copperhead



**Length** 23½–51 in (60–130 cm)  
**Breeding** Viviparous  
**Habit** Terrestrial  
**Status** Least concern

**Location** C. and S.E. USA



The copperhead is boldly marked with chestnut-brown or orange bands on a gray, tan, or pinkish background. In spring and fall, it basks during the day, but it becomes nocturnal in summer. This viper lies practically hidden among dead leaves or rocks waiting to ambush rodents, frogs,

lizards, and invertebrates, using the heat-sensitive pits between its eyes and nostrils to locate prey in total darkness. Its bite is venomous, but rarely serious for humans. The female gives birth to 1–15 young every other year.



*Bothriechis schlegelii*

Eyelash pit viper



**Length** 18–30 in (45–75 cm)  
**Breeding** Viviparous  
**Habit** Arboreal  
**Status** Not evaluated

**Location** Central America, N. South America



This tropical forest snake is one of a number of pit vipers that live in trees. Like most arboreal snakes, it has a prehensile tail and good binocular

vision, but it also has distinctive “eyelashes,” formed by raised scales above its eyes. Active at night, it preys on lizards, frogs, and small rodents, and lies in wait near forest flowers to catch hummingbirds as they come to feed. Eyelash pit vipers vary greatly in color, ranging from an intense orange-yellow to grayish green.



*Bothrops atrox*

Common lancehead

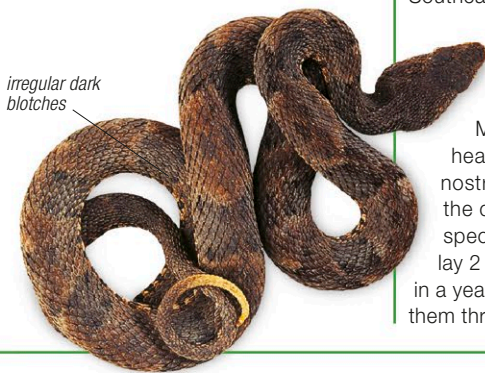


**Length** 3¼ ft (1 m), max 5 ft (1.5 m)  
**Breeding** Viviparous  
**Habit** Terrestrial  
**Status** Not evaluated

**Location** N. South America



This is one of the most dangerous snakes in South America because of its rapid strike, potent venom, and its tendency to live near human habitations. Heat-sensitive pits between the eyes and nostrils enable it to detect prey in the darkness. It is also called the fer-de-lance, though some reserve this name for a West Indian species that has a similarly pointed head. Males have longer tails than females, and may fight during the breeding season. Females may give birth to up to 100 young. Juveniles have brightly colored tail tips, which they use to lure prey.



*Calloselasma rhodostoma*

Malaysian pit viper



**Length** 28–39 in (70–100 cm)  
**Breeding** Oviparous  
**Habit** Terrestrial  
**Status** Least concern

**Location** S.E. Asia



This highly venomous snake, usually found at the edges of forests and in clearings, is quick to strike, and is the cause of many snake-bite fatalities in Southeast Asia. It is purplish brown, with light-edged, darker triangles on its flanks, and has a pointed snout. A nocturnal hunter, the Malaysian pit viper uses the heat pits between its eyes and nostrils to help it to locate prey in the dark. Unlike most vipers, this species lays eggs—the female may lay 2 clutches of 13–25 eggs each in a year—and remains coiled around them throughout their incubation.

*Crotalus durissus*

Tropical rattlesnake



**Length** 3¼ ft (1 m), max 5 ft (1.5 m)  
**Breeding** Viviparous  
**Habit** Terrestrial  
**Status** Least concern

**Location** Central America, South America



The bite of the tropical rattlesnake is highly venomous—about 75 percent of untreated bites result in fatalities. There are 14 subspecies recognized, with highly variable coloring, but this is the only rattlesnake over much of its range. Heavily built, it has a broad head and obvious heat-sensitive pits, to detect prey in total darkness. This nocturnal species spends the day coiled, partly hidden by vegetation. The female gives birth to 6–12 young.

*Crotalus cerastes*

Sidewinder



**Length** 18–32 in (45–80 cm)  
**Breeding** Viviparous  
**Habit** Terrestrial  
**Status** Least concern

**Location** S.W. USA, N.W. Mexico



The sidewinder is the stoutest of all rattlesnakes and is the only one in which the female is smaller than the male. It has a highly distinctive way of moving—an adaptation to life on windblown desert sand. It feeds mainly on small lizards and rodents, often ambushing its prey from the cover of isolated shrubs. Although sidewinders can be aggressive, by rattlesnake standards their bite is not especially dangerous. Their young are born in late summer, in clutches of 6–12.

BODY COLORATION

The sidewinder varies from cream, gray, tan, or brown to pinkish, depending on the soil on which it lives; markings are poorly defined.



MOVING ON SAND



Sidewinding is a form of movement used by several snake species that live on loose sand. Instead of sliding forward, with its body in contact with the sand, a sidewinding snake throws itself over the surface, following a diagonal path. This kind of movement creates characteristic parallel tracks.

*Lachesis muta*

Bushmaster



**Length** 8¼ ft (2.5 m), max 12 ft (3.6 m)  
**Breeding** Oviparous  
**Habit** Terrestrial  
**Status** Not evaluated

**Location** S. Central America, N. South America



The bushmaster is the longest viper in the world. It is also one of the most venomous, with a 20 percent mortality rate, even if treated; however, it generally avoids contact with humans. A secretive species, it ambushes prey at night—coiled and ready to strike—along a mammal trail. It has a slender, yellow or tan body with black markings. Unusually for a viper, females lay eggs (about 8–15), guarding them until they hatch.

